All I Know About Animal Behavior I Learned in Loehmann's Dressing Room

By Erma Bombeck

INTRODUCTION

Men and women are very different models of the same species . . . How do I know this? Well, my time is limited, so let's narrow it down to one prime example: Directions.

Observation #1: *Women cannot use a map without turning the map to correspond to the direction that they are heading.*

Observation #2: *Men will not stop to ask for directions: they'd rather drive for 50 miles in the wrong direction than appear to not know where they are going.*

And keep in mind this is from the female perspective!!

All I Know About Animal Behavior I Learned in Loehmann's Dressing Room by Erma Bombeck

NARRATOR: **(Chapter 3)** I have just come up with a wonderful solution to end all wars. Let men give directions on how to get there. There is no species on the face of this earth that prides itself more on how to

4NG Fanatics

get around than men. Yet most of them are lost their entire lifetimes. They just won't admit it.

I can always tell when my husband is lost. He starts to dispense guilt.

HUSBAND: Are you sure you read the route number right?

NARRATOR: And as we're knee-deep in farm animals staring in our windows,

HUSBAND: Did AAA say anything about a detour?

NARRATOR: If you really want to set a man off, tell him to stop and ask someone where you are.

HUSBAND: Why should I do that?

NARRATOR: Because we are lost.

HUSBAND: I am not lost. I just made a wrong turn.

NARRATOR: Same thing. We have passed this gas station three times.

HUSBAND: That's a good thing. At least it's familiar.

NARRATOR: To stop and ask someone for directions is to compromise his masculinity.

Despite the fact that men don't have a clue where they are most of the time, they insist on giving directions to women…a process better known as death by instruction.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I am standing at the door with my car keys in my hand.

HUSBAND: Do you know where you're going?

NARRATOR: Yes

HUSBAND: I thought not *(putting down his paper).* You go west on Silver Street for two blocks and then turn north until you reach the highway. At the freeway, go east and . . .

NARRATOR: Now that drives me crazy! He knows I don't speak compass. Unless you're talking about the Civil War, north and south have no meaning to me. North is always opposite my right hand and south my left, no matter which way I'm standing. The same with miles. I walked a mile once and it was the longest hour and a half I ever spent, so forget miles. *(to husband, begging)* Tell me right or left.

HUSBAND: *(patiently)* I have tried giving you directions in left and right.

NARRATOR: And?

HUSBAND: You have still gotten lost. Let me draw you a map.

NARRATOR: Oh Lord, forget it. Just tell me when I get to the end of the street, which way do I turn?

4NG Fanatics

HUSBAND: North . . . rather right. Then turn right again and if you are blinded by the sun you are going in the wrong direction.

NARRATOR: I always thought the sun came up in the east.

HUSBAND: Not at 4:30 in the afternoon.

NARRATOR: Why do you always try to confuse me? I think you do that to make yourself feel important.

HUSBAND: Why can't you have a little patience?

NARRATOR: At my age, patience is not a virtue…it's a luxury. *(beat)* Wherever lost women gather…at service stations, in obscure corn fields, and on exit ramps . . . we talk about this thing men have about giving directions. One woman told an unbelievable story one day about being lost. She stopped at a service station.

WOMAN: I am trying to find where my son's baseball team is practicing. I'm looking for Prindle's Field.

MAN: Prindle's field is about three miles west of Dake's Corners off the Hans Expressway using the Mill Road exit. *(Strokes chin)* You go by two stop signs, make a right at the overhead, and there's a church on the corner that used to be Presbyterian but was bought out by the Methodists. You take a jog in the road and follow

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

through to a dead end, then turn left and you'll see a little filling station called Fred's.

WOMAN: That's the name of this station. *(looking up at sign)* Where's Prindle's Field?

MAN: That's what I'm getting around to telling you. You're there. It's behind the station.

NARRATOR: The male species has a superiority complex about driving. I wish I had a dime for every joke about woman drivers I've been assaulted with. They relish telling about the woman in driving school who consistently flunked her test because she couldn't be sure which was her right hand and which was her left. Years later she met her old driving instructor.

INSTRUCTOR: So have you ever figured it out?

WOMAN 2: Certainly. I drive every day now. *(holding up both hands).* Ruby ring, right and diamond ring, left.

NARRATOR: Women have their jokes on men who drive. My favorite is: If a man and a woman jumped off a building at the same time, who would reach the ground first? Answer? The woman. The man would get lost.

Douglass Corrigan never asked for directions. He just announced to a crowd of reporters and cameras in 1938

4NG Fanatics

that he was headed for California, hopped into his monoplane, and to the horror of the people on the ground, made a wide circle and ended up in Dublin, Ireland.

Roy Riegels never asked. He was the USC center who was pitted against Georgia in the Rose Bowl game in 1929. When a Georgia player fumbled, Riegels came up with the ball and started a dash to the goal line. Unfortunately, it was the wrong one. His own man finally stopped him on the three-yard line.

And while we're talking heroes, Christopher Columbus wasn't all that swift. Turn the guy around in the Bahamas a couple of times and he couldn't find America if it was on fire.

You can say what you want about women's lack of direction, but it was a man who was found by police officer recently, sitting in his car alongside Interstate 8 where it stops at Ocean Beach in San Diego. He had a map in his lap and perplexed look on his face. The motorist told the officer he had come from New Mexico

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

and was looking for Arizona. He said he must have missed it.

I don't care what they say about animals having great sonar powers and whales showing up in the Baja every year. How do we know they want to go to Mexico? For all we know, they year headed for Hawaii, but the male was too proud to ask directions.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Erma Bombeck
ISBN: 978-0060177881
Publisher: Harper Collins
Date (Month/Year): Oct 1995

AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY